

SUBIR HALDER



Peace in Tatters

KOLKATA Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya has lost his patience. Over 10 months after Nandigram in West Bengal turned into a war zone, the area, which was once the venue for the state's most ambitious SEZ, continues to burn. Following renewed violence in the East Midnapore pocket on October 27—where the administration and police have not been able to enter since March 14—Bhattacharya has written to Home Minister Shivraj Patil seeking CRPF inter-

vention in Nandigram.

On October 28, three men believed to be CPI(M) supporters died due to a freak explosion at Khejuri, a party stronghold, while allegedly making crude bombs. Following that, the Trinamool Congress-backed Bhoomi Uchhed Pratirodh Committee is said to have torched a local CPI(M) office. In retaliation, CPI(M) supporters fired indiscriminately in villages, killing one and critically injuring four.

Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee,

GRITTY: Banerjee refuses to back off from Nandigram who was touring the area, also claimed that her convoy had been shot at, presenting an empty .303 shell as proof.

The chief minister, for whom Nandigram has been the biggest administrative failure in his seven-year tenure, says that he was forced to seek CRPF help and has also sought to resolve the situation politically. He says that he is willing to agree to the Opposition's demands if it meant restoration of peace at Nandigram. Banerjee, however, still refuses to enter into talks with him.

Meanwhile, the state continues to be rocked by bandhs. The Khejuri-Nandigram area came to a standstill while the SUCI and the Trinamool Congress called for statewide bandhs. On October 30, tension escalated at Nandigram again with journalists being thrashed by CPI(M) workers.

Peace, for the time being, has a long way to go before it reaches Nandigram.

by Swagata Sen

SIGNPOSTS

SENTENCED: Dara Singh, who is serving two life terms for killing missionary Graham Staines and a Christian priest, to life imprisonment for the murder of a garment trader in 1999.



ISSUED: To Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi, a notice by the Supreme

Court for defying court orders and observing a partial bandh in the state.

PASSED: By the US House of Representatives, a resolution recognising the "religious and historical significance" of Diwali, by a vote of 358-0.

ADJUDGED: NRI doctor Lord Khalid Hamid, 62, as the Asian of the Year 2007 by the Asian Who's Who 2007, for his contribution to health service. He is the chairman of the Alpha Hospital Group and chairman and CEO of the London International Hospital.

VIS-A-VIS MAYAWATI Uttar Pradesh chief minister **versus RITA BAHUGUNA JOSHI** Uttar Pradesh Congress president

“
Mahatma Gandhi divided Indian society along caste lines into upper and lower castes.
”



SAURABH SINGH

“
When Gandhian ideology is taught all over the world, such a derogatory statement against him is intolerable. She should apologise.
”

EPILOGUE: His ideology may or may not find many takers, but Gandhi still makes news.